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THE BREAKS BIBLE

Free Sampler: 10 of the Most-Sampled Breaks



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Free Sampler

What's this?

This is a free taste of **The Breaks Bible**: the full guide to the 100 most-sampled breaks in music history. The original record, who flipped it, which pressing to hunt, and what to pay. Ten entries below. The other ninety are coming.

Get the full book: *The Breaks Bible*, 100 entries, $19 ($14 for the first 100 with code EARLYBIRD). Buy it at **diggininthesalescrates.com/bundle**

THE 10 ENTRIES

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1 The Amen break

ORIGINAL

The Winstons: "Amen, Brother" (1969), Metromedia (B-side of "Color Him Father")

THE BREAK

About 1:26 into the track, the band drops out and drummer Gregory Coleman plays a four-bar solo. Six to seven seconds that became the most sampled drum break in history. The kicker: it was filler. The band needed a B-side for "Color Him Father," cut an instrumental based on the gospel song "Amen" in about 20 minutes, and the track was too short, so Coleman stretched it with a solo. The A-side won a Grammy. The B-side rewrote music. Neither Coleman (who died homeless in 2006) nor bandleader Richard L. Spencer (who owned the copyright and didn't learn about the sampling until 1996, past the statute of limitations) ever saw royalties. In May 2026, the Library of Congress added "Amen, Brother" to the National Recording Registry.

SAMPLED IN

N.W.A: "Straight Outta Compton"; The Prodigy: "Firestarter"; Salt-N-Pepa: "I Desire" (1986, one of the first)

PRESSING TO HUNT

The OG is the 1969 Metromedia 45 (MMS-117): "Color Him Father" on the A-side, the break on the flip. There are also UK (Pye), Canadian, and Japanese pressings from 1969. On a budget, the *Ultimate Breaks & Beats* compilations carry a clean copy.

WHAT TO PAY

A clean OG copy still costs more than most diggers expect for a Metromedia 45. Expect $15–$40 even for a player copy; clean copies push past $75. Don't overpay for later foreign pressings unless the condition is excellent.

DIGGING TIP

This 45 hides in oldies and soul 45 boxes filed under "W" for Winstons. Most sellers still don't know the B-side is the most valuable six seconds in music.

2 The Think break

ORIGINAL

Lyn Collins: "Think (About It)" (1972), People Records

THE BREAK

James Brown signed Texas soul singer Lyn Collins to his People imprint and produced this himself, and the whole record is a break in disguise. The famous passage is the breakdown where Collins shouts "Woo! Yeah!" over Jabo Starks' drums. Producers have been lifting both the drums and her ad-libs for 40 years. It's the rare break where the vocal shouts are as sampled as the drums.

SAMPLED IN

Rob Base & DJ E-Z Rock: "It Takes Two" (the drums); Snoop Dogg: "Ain't No Fun (If the Homies Can't Have None)"; J Dilla: "Ash Rockin" (1996)

PRESSING TO HUNT

The 1972 People 45 is the one. It also appears on the *Think (About It)* LP (1972) if you want the full album. Avoid paying a premium for the countless JB compilation appearances. They're sonically fine but they don't appreciate.

WHAT TO PAY

The OG 45 is still affordable, typically $10–$40 depending on condition. This is one of the best value-for-legend ratios in the whole book.

DIGGING TIP

Filed under Collins, not Brown. That's why it survives in dollar bins. Check JB-adjacent soul 45 boxes; dealers price the Brown 45s high and miss the People-label gems sitting next to them.

3 Funky Drummer

ORIGINAL

James Brown: "Funky Drummer (Pts. 1 & 2)" (1970), King (drums: Clyde Stubblefield)

THE BREAK

Brown shouts "give the drummer some" and Clyde Stubblefield takes it from there. Around 5:34 on the full take: ghost notes, hi-hat, swagger. The most imitated drum pattern ever recorded. Stubblefield, like Coleman before him, never received royalties for the thousands of records built on his playing. He spent his later years as a working drummer in Madison, Wisconsin, and died in 2017. BDP flipped it early on "South Bronx"; Public Enemy's Bomb Squad chopping it into "Fight the Power" made it among the most famous.

SAMPLED IN

Public Enemy: "Fight the Power"; Boogie Down Productions: "South Bronx"; LL Cool J: "Mama Said Knock You Out"; Dr. Dre: "Let Me Ride"

PRESSING TO HUNT

The 1970 King 45 (6290) is the OG. But the smart money is the *In the Jungle Groove* LP (1986): Brown's compilation built specifically around the breaks, with an extended "Funky Drummer." Usually cheaper than the 45 and a better listen.

WHAT TO PAY

OG 45s typically run $30-$80. *In the Jungle Groove* on vinyl: $50–$100 for clean copies. Don't pay collector prices for the endless JB greatest-hits comps.

DIGGING TIP

The 45 is common enough that patience pays. Wait for a VG+ copy under $40 rather than grabbing the first $80 listing. And check the *In the Jungle Groove* LP whenever you see it; it's the cheapest legitimate way to own the extended break.

4 Impeach the President

ORIGINAL

The Honey Drippers: "Impeach the President" (1973), Alaga

THE BREAK

The opening seconds: a crisp, snapping snare and a slightly swung hi-hat pattern. It might be the most-used drum intro in hip-hop. The story is pure crate-digger mythology: producer Roy C. (Roy Hammond) pulled together a group of teenagers from Jamaica High School in Queens, recorded a Watergate protest song in a basement, and pressed it on his own Alaga imprint, reportedly only about a hundred copies. Kool Herc reportedly found it early and masked the label to keep it secret. Marley Marl blew it open in 1985, reprogramming the kick and snare for MC Shan's "The Bridge." It's been on a commercially released record every year since the mid-80s.

SAMPLED IN

The Notorious B.I.G.: "Unbelievable"; Audio Two: "Top Billin'"; J. Cole: "Wet Dreamz"

PRESSING TO HUNT

The 1973 Alaga OG 45 is the grail, and genuinely rare. For everyone else, Tuff City reissued it (2017, 2019) in proper quality; those are the affordable, great-sounding copies.

WHAT TO PAY

OG Alaga 45s are $150-$400 when they surface. Verify the label carefully: the Robert Plant "Honeydrippers" are a different group entirely. Tuff City reissues: $15-$30. Never pay OG money without clear label photos.

DIGGING TIP

The number one thing to check: the label must read Alaga and the artist must be THE Honey Drippers (Roy C.'s group), not Robert Plant's 80s project. This is the most commonly confused credit in the book. When in doubt, pass.

5 La Di Da Di

ORIGINAL

Doug E. Fresh & MC Ricky D (Slick Rick): "La Di Da Di" (1985), Reality (B-side of "The Show")

THE BREAK

Not a drum break. A vocal break. The whole record is Doug E. Fresh beatboxing while a 20-year-old Slick Rick spins a day-in-the-life story, and producers have been lifting the "la di da di, we like to party" chant and the "party people in the house" call for forty years. It was the B-side. "The Show" was supposed to be the hit. Instead it became one of the most sampled vocals in hip-hop history. In April 2024 the Library of Congress inducted it into the National Recording Registry.

SAMPLED IN

The Notorious B.I.G.: "Hypnotize" (1997, interpolation of the "party people" vocal); Snoop Dogg: "Lodi Dodi" (1993, a full cover-flip of the whole song); Beyoncé feat. André 3000: "Party" (2011, vocals and lyrics; Kanye West built the beat around the "we like to party" chant)

PRESSING TO HUNT

The 1985 Reality 12" of "The Show." The break is on the flip. Later in 1985 it got its own promotional 12" as the lead track; either works.

WHAT TO PAY

The OG 12" is affordable, typically $5–$15. This is one of the cheapest cornerstones in the whole book.

DIGGING TIP

Sellers price "The Show" as the A-side, but the B-side is the one producers wore out. Check the runout. Early Reality pressings are the ones to own.

6 The Big Beat

ORIGINAL

Billy Squier: "The Big Beat" (1980), Capitol (from *The Tale of the Tape*; drums: Bobby Chouinard)

THE BREAK

The opening seconds: Chouinard's thunderous kick and snare, overdubbed with Squier himself beating a snare case with his hands, captured with cavernous room ambience. Massive gated-reverb drums with huge open space between the hits, tailor-made for a Bronx kid with two turntables. The song never charted; as of 2020 it had been sampled in nearly 300 recordings. And unlike the funk drummers in this book, Squier got paid: he reportedly demands up to 75% of a sampling song's royalties.

SAMPLED IN

Jay-Z: "99 Problems" (2003, Rick Rubin, who clearly has a thing for Squier); Run-DMC: "Here We Go" (1985); Big Daddy Kane: "Ain't No Half-Steppin'" (1988, the vocal chant, not the drums). Also Alicia Keys' "Girl on Fire" and UTFO's "Roxanne, Roxanne."

PRESSING TO HUNT

The Tale of the Tape LP (Capitol, 1980). It's the opening track. A common arena-rock LP, which is exactly why it's cheap.

WHAT TO PAY

$5–$20 for clean copies. It's everywhere. Never pay collector prices.

DIGGING TIP

Squier's whole early catalog is a break mine. "The Stroke" became Eminem's "Berzerk." When you see *The Tale of the Tape* in a rock bin, remember: sellers file it as dad rock, not as a hip-hop cornerstone.

7 Scorpio

ORIGINAL

Dennis Coffey & the Detroit Guitar Band: "Scorpio" (1971), Sussex (from *Evolution*)

THE BREAK

The mid-song breakdown runs a full 24 bars of drums and congas before bassist Bob Babbitt even joins in. Over half the song is just drums and bass. Uriel Jones and Richard "Pistol" Allen on drums, Eddie "Bongo" Brown on congas, Jack Ashford on tambourine. And the intro is nine guitar riffs overdubbed across three octaves, left wide open and uncluttered. Coffey himself said that's what made it loopable. It shouldn't have been a hit at all: an instrumental with an extended drum solo that went to #6 on the Hot 100 and sold over a million copies. Paul Winley's *Super Disco Brakes* Vol. 1 (1979) put it in front of the hip-hop generation.

SAMPLED IN

Public Enemy: "Night of the Living Baseheads"; LL Cool J: "Jingling Baby"; Young MC: "Bust a Move." Also Mark Ronson's "Ooh Wee."

PRESSING TO HUNT

Evolution LP (Sussex, 1971). The whole record is a sample mine ("Getting It On" too). The "Scorpio" 45 (B-side "Sad Angel") for the single-track hunters.

WHAT TO PAY

Evolution originals typically $10–$30 depending on condition; the 45 is cheaper and turns up in oldies boxes.

DIGGING TIP

Coffey was a Funk Brother. His solo LPs get filed under rock/soul, not funk. Look for the Sussex label; Clarence Avant's indie pressings are the ones that hold value.

8 N.T.

ORIGINAL

Kool & the Gang: "N.T." (1971), De-Lite (from *Live at P.J.'s*)

THE BREAK

The drum break, George "Funky" Brown behind the kit, supposedly short for "No Title." A deep-cut album track with an open drum passage that DJs prized: dry, funky, and endlessly loopable. It's the sound of Kool & the Gang before "Celebration": a raw Jersey funk band, not a disco outfit.

SAMPLED IN

Nas: "It Ain't Hard to Tell" (1994); N.W.A: "Gangsta Gangsta" (1988, the drums); Q-Tip: "Breathe and Stop" (1999, the "N.T." drums under the whole track)

PRESSING TO HUNT

Live at P.J.'s (De-Lite, 1971). "N.T." is a deep cut, so you want the whole LP.

WHAT TO PAY

Early Kool & the Gang LPs are common, $25–$40 for clean copies. Don't pay a premium for the track name; most sellers don't know it's there.

DIGGING TIP

Learn the De-Lite label. The 1969-73 Kool & the Gang records are the funk band; everything after the late '70s is a different outfit, sonically. The break records hide in the dollar bins because sellers price the disco hits.

9 Genius of Love

ORIGINAL

Tom Tom Club: "Genius of Love" (1981), Sire

THE BREAK

Not a drum break. The whole rhythm track. Tina Weymouth's rubbery bassline, Chris Frantz's drums, Adrian Belew's guitar, the steel drums: one of the most sampled rhythm tracks of the '80s. A Talking Heads side project that accidentally wrote a forever-loop. Note the lineage carefully: Mariah Carey's "Fantasy" samples it directly; Latto's "Big Energy" *interpolates* it (re-played, not lifted).

SAMPLED IN

Mariah Carey: "Fantasy" (1995); Mark Morrison: "Return of the Mack" (1996); Latto: "Big Energy" (2021, interpolation, which then got a Mariah Carey remix, closing the loop)

PRESSING TO HUNT

Tom Tom Club LP (Sire, 1981) or the "Genius of Love" 12" single. The 12" has the extended mix, which is the DJ-friendly one.

WHAT TO PAY

Common, $10-$20 for the LP or 12". Never pay up for this one.

DIGGING TIP

While you're in the T section, check *Close to the Bone* (1983): "The Man Who Used to Be" is another sleeper. Tom Tom Club records sit in new-wave bins, not funk bins. That's the arbitrage.

10 I Want'a Do Something Freaky to You

ORIGINAL

Leon Haywood: "I Want'a Do Something Freaky to You" (1975), 20th Century (from *Come and Get Yourself Some*)

THE BREAK

Not a drum break. A groove. The record opens with Haywood's warbling Minimoog synth lead floating over a deep, rolling bassline, and that's the whole sample: Dr. Dre lifted the groove practically intact for "Nuthin' but a 'G' Thang" and built the G-funk sound on it, borrowed from a '75 slow jam. Haywood, a Texas-born soul singer who'd been cutting records since the '60s, scored his biggest hit with this one; then it became something even bigger: raw material.

SAMPLED IN

Dr. Dre feat. Snoop Dogg: "Nuthin' but a 'G' Thang" (1992, the G-funk blueprint; the Haywood groove *is* the track); 50 Cent: "Corner Bodega" (2000, documented on WhoSampled)

PRESSING TO HUNT

Come and Get Yourself Some LP (20th Century, 1975). The track opens the record. The "I Want'a Do Something Freaky to You" 45 for the single-track hunters.

WHAT TO PAY

The LP is common, typically $20-$50 for clean originals. The 45: $10-$25. Never pay collector prices for a record that sits in oldies bins everywhere.

DIGGING TIP

Haywood gets filed under quiet-storm soul and oldies. Sellers don't price him as a hip-hop cornerstone. Learn the 20th Century label; his records hide next to the slow-jam 45s, not the funk.

Want all 100?

This sampler is 10 of 100. The full **Breaks Bible** covers the complete canon: every break, every pressing, every price. It is out now for $19.
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